



Voicing concern: India and Mumbai all-rounder Shardul Thakur recently expressed his dissatisfaction with the tightly packed 10 consecutive rounds of Ranji matches, with only three days' respite in between games. EMMANUAL YOGINI

fixture until the One-Day Cup and the Vitality Blast intersperse the championship games.

Siddharth Kaul, the veteran Punjab speedster, echoed his sentiments about the issue during the Sportstar Sports Conclave in Chandigarh in February. But when a current Indian star speaks out, it has an immediate impact. That is what happened after Thakur's statement. It set in motion a chain of events. First, India head coach Rahul Dravid reacted to Thakur's statement after the Test series against England culminated in Dharamsala. While Dravid admitted the "need to look at and see how we can manage our domestic schedules," he stressed the need to rework the schedule and hear from domestic players and coaches more.

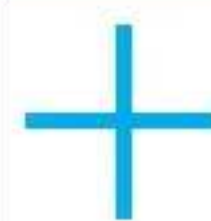
The week after, the BCCI found itself in a damage-control mode and formed an internal panel consisting of Dravid, National Cricket Academy head VVS Laxman, chief selector Ajit Agarkar, and general manager Abey Kuruvilla. All four members of the

panel have been through the grind of domestic cricket since the 1990s, and they will put their heads together to try and resolve the conundrum.

However, Kuruvilla, who is now responsible for the conduct of domestic cricket, will have his hands tied unless given the freedom to do away with a couple of redundant tournaments. The appointment of the panel is a welcome step, although it has yet to be announced officially.

The BCCI must bring back the annual captains and coaches conclave during the off-season. The last time the domestic captains and coaches assembled and shared their suggestions with the BCCI was in 2016 when the Committee of Administrators appointed by the Supreme Court was in charge.

Despite the elected office-bearers taking over, the captains and coaches conclave, a regular feature for more than a decade, has not been revived yet. In fact, Dravid hinted at resuming the practice.



Ranji Trophy duration

2012-13: 86 days – 11 rounds – 47 match-days per team

2013-14: 99 days – 11 rounds – 47 match-days per team

2015-16: 65 days – 8 rounds – 32 match-days per team

2016-17: 101 days – 11/12 rounds – 47/51 match-days per team

2019-20: 96 days – 11/12 rounds – 47/51 match-days per team

2023-24: 70 days – 10 rounds – 43 match-days per team

"Maybe we need to re-look and see whether some of the tournaments we are conducting are necessary in this day and age or if they are not necessary. There needs to be an all-round review [involving] coaches and players, especially the guys who are part of the domestic circuit," he said in Dharamsala.

At a time when the BCCI has issued a directive to top cricketers to start playing Ranji Trophy regularly, getting the schedule right for the premiere domestic cricket championships is its responsibility. When teams have to play 10 rounds until the final, the tournament has to have at least a three-month window.

The problem is that if the BCCI starts the Ranji Trophy on October 1 and finishes it without any break, it will be unable to schedule the SMAT before the IPL auction. Perhaps the most sensible option is to start the Inter-State tournaments with the Ranji Trophy league stage and end the domestic season with the Ranji knockouts. It would mean the Ranji League stage — even with a four-day break between games, a basic necessity for travel and recovery — can be completed in October and November. It can be followed by the SMAT T20 Trophy in November–December and the Vijay Hazare Trophy in January.

Will the domestic cricketers' plea be heard in time ahead of the next season? Watch this space.